

Our חכמים tell us in מסכת סוטה (5a): [שבגאון]: תלמיד חכם צריך שיהא בו אחד משמונה בשמינית. This is a cryptic statement. Even though גאון is generally considered a distasteful and disfavored מידה, nevertheless, a תלמיד should have this “one-eighth of one-eighth” of גאון.

The גאון derives this concept from this week's פרשה, פרשת וישלח. In the תפילה that יעקב אבינו davened to save him from the הקדוש ברוך הוא, עשו, he says (32:11): קטנתי מכל החסדים. The גאון notes that this פסוק is found in the eighth פרשה of the תורה, פרשת וישלח, and it is the eighth פסוק in the פרשה. From this, he explains, we learn a critical lesson: even though יעקב אבינו had so much to take pride in - his large משפחה, his wealth, and the נחת from his accomplishments - he still recognized and proclaimed מכל החסדים. This perspective reflects ענוה, a hallmark of true greatness. According to the גאון, the proper way to utilize ענוה is to channel it towards ענוה, keeping oneself grounded even amidst success.

Another פשוט on this פסוק offers a complementary perspective. יעקב אבינו says (32:11): קטנתי מכל החסדים ומכל. He acknowledges the tremendous kindnesses the הקדוש ברוך הוא has done for him. However, there seems to be a קושיא here: how could יעקב imply that he merited all of these חסדים on his own? After all, we know that all the חסדים and goodness we receive from the הקדוש ברוך הוא are in the זכות of the אבות. For instance, when דוד המלך sought to build the המקדש, בית שלמה המלך could not get the doors to open until he invoked the זכות of דוד המלך.

The תירוץ given is based on this very פסוק. When יעקב אבינו reflects on the חסדים of the past, he says קטנתי, expressing gratitude for what the הקדוש ברוך הוא has already done for him, acknowledging that he may have tried as hard as he could to earn it. However, when looking to the future, יעקב admits his dependence on זכות אבות. He says קטנתי, recognizing his limitations and placing his trust in the זכות of the generations that came before him.

This is a crucial lesson for us as well. When considering the past, we must humbly appreciate what the הקדוש ברוך הוא has done for us. But when looking to the future, we rely on זכות אבות and daven for continued ישועה. This is reflected in our daily תפילות, especially in שמונה עשרה, where we invoke the זכות of our אבות.

May we take this message to heart, recognizing both our accomplishments and our dependence on the זכות of the פריעדיקע generations, those who came before us.

